"I think it will happen in the future," says Singh. "But when you have numbers of scale, you cannot ignore the problem."

Many parents send their children to special education schools. While these institutions do not provide board certificates, they can facilitate a degree from the National Institute of Open Schooling. "Many parents pressure their children to go to a regular school, where they are not given the attention they need," says the mother of Samar Milan, 18, from Indore. "Why should what people think matter? If your child is improving, that is where the focus should lie."

Therapists also point out the difference between inclusion and integration. Inclusion may see a child with autism sit amongst neurotypicals at school, but integration is what provides them support in learning and interacting with the world around them. And, most regular schools are unable to provide either because children with autism need individual learning programmes, special educators and sensitised peers. Mugdha Kalra, whose 13-year-old son Madhav goes to a special school, says, "Madhav is moderate on the spectrum. I understand what he needs and that at this point of time, a regular school cannot provide it."

THE EMERGENCE OF A TIGHT-KNIT COMMUNITY IS ACTING AS A SUPPORT GROUP FOR AUTISTIC PEOPLE AND CAREGIVERS

NEW AREAS OF SUPPORT

Despite improvements in diagnosis and treatment, the struggle for autistic children and their parents continues. To begin with, advanced treatment remains expensive. Parents have to pay for therapies, special school fees and often a shadow teacher at a regular school. No insurance policy covers therapy in India. Also, for an autistic child to receive a concession in examinations, he or she needs to get a disability certificate from a government hospital. "Autism manifestations differ so much that it takes multiple sittings for them to certify it as autism," says Madhav's mum Mugdha. "Madhav had 14 sittings in this process." Then there is the process of supporting children once they are adults. Most parents apply to be their legal guardian or set up a trust fund, which requires the disability certificate again after they turn 18.

The emotional toll on autistic persons and their caregivers is high. Mothers carry a disproportionate amount of guilt and are often blamed or shamed. "I always felt like I was not doing enough," says Rohan's mother Shilpi. "My entire life for some time was spent running from therapist to therapist. My husband didn't think of sharing that responsibility, but pointed out my failures." Seeing parents stressed adds to the emotional confusion for the child. Often, both parents and their autistic offspring get diagnosed with anxiety or depression.

However, a tightly-knit autistic community, both in India and abroad, has become a useful support group for those who have an autistic child or are autistic themselves. "I ask all mothers of autistic children to look after themselves," says Shilpi. "You did not cause the condition. You have a right to relax, to be proud of all that you do." For Rakesh, connecting with the neurodivergent community helped improve his self-worth. "I see parts of myself in each of them and the feeling of belonging has been healing," he says.

A number of organisations help people with autism find employment, giving them a sense of purpose in life. Action for Autism has a residential campus to skill-train 600 people near Kolkata and then place them. "We also visit companies, and regular and special schools to train them on how to support and manage autistic people," says Sakhi Singhi, senior project coordinator, Action for Autism, Kolkata. Some of their trainees are now working at MNCs, data firms and art centres.

The West has struggled with the stigma around autism for decades to create a positive space for neurodiversity. Everything from early eugenics to the anti-vaxx movement (which touted autism as one of the main risks of vaccines) contributed to a kind of phobia of neurodivergence where it was seen as a fundamentally undesirable condition, a 'disease' to be eradicated. Even autism advocacy groups have been accused of participating in and reinforcing the 'ableist' discourse. But now there's a growing realisation that not all people have the same neurological wiring and that there needs to be space and respect for all. India, too, is seeing a movement in that direction. And that gives parents of autistic children some hope, where previously there was none. ■

THE HOPE, AND THE CHALLENGE

HELP FOR AUTISTIC PERSONS

- Some schools are investing in special education teachers for the inclusion of autistic children in classrooms and intervention for their needs
- Organisations like Action for Autism help autistic persons develop skills and find employment
- A growing autism community is advocating a more neurodiverse society through digital campaigns and outreach programmes

CHALLENGES THAT REMAIN

- Treatment and schooling are expensive
- Social integration in school is difficult; bullying of autistic children and their families is rampant
- Disability certification for people with autism through government colleges can take up to one year due to the ambiguity of symptoms